part of the magistrate was soon rectified by the Punjab Government who hastened to send a telegram ordering the release of the offender against the Act (This case has been taken from Miss E.F. Rathbone's interesting little book *Child Marriage*.)

What were we doing all this time? We were in prison. For six years now we have been mostly in prison, sometimes as many as sixty or seventy thousand at a time. Outside, a strict censorship prevailed, meetings were forbidden and an attempt to enter a rural area was almost certain to lead to prison, if not worse. The various emergency laws and denial of civil liberties were certainly not aimed at preventing support of the Sarda Act. But in effect they left the field clear to the opponents of that measure. And the Government in its distress at having to combat a great political movement directed against it, sought allies in the most reactionary of religious and social bigots. To obtain their goodwill the Sarda Act was sat upon, extinguished. *Hindu Musalman ekta ki jai* – Victory to Hindu-Muslim Unity!

The Muslims deserve their full share in this victory. Most of us had thought that the child-wife evil was largely confined to Hindus. But whatever the early disproportion might have been, Muslims were evidently determined not to be outdistanced in this matter as in others, by Hindus. So while on the one hand they claimed more seats in the council, more jobs as policemen, deputy collectors, tahsildars, chaprasis and the like, they hurried on with the work of increasing their child-wives. From the most noted taluqadars in Oudh to the humble workers, they all joined in this endeavour, till at last the 1931 census proclaimed that victory had come to them. The report of the Age of Consent Committee had previously prepared us to revise our previous opinion but the census went much further than had been expected.[32] It told us that Muslims had actually surpassed the Hindus in the proportion of their child-wives. In Assam 'Muslims have now far the largest proportion of child-wives in all the early age groups', in Bihar and Orissa [now Odisha], the census tells us that 'Whereas the proportion of Hindu girl wives (including widows) below the age of ten has increased since 1921 from 103 to 160, among Muslims it has increased from 76 to 202.' Truly a